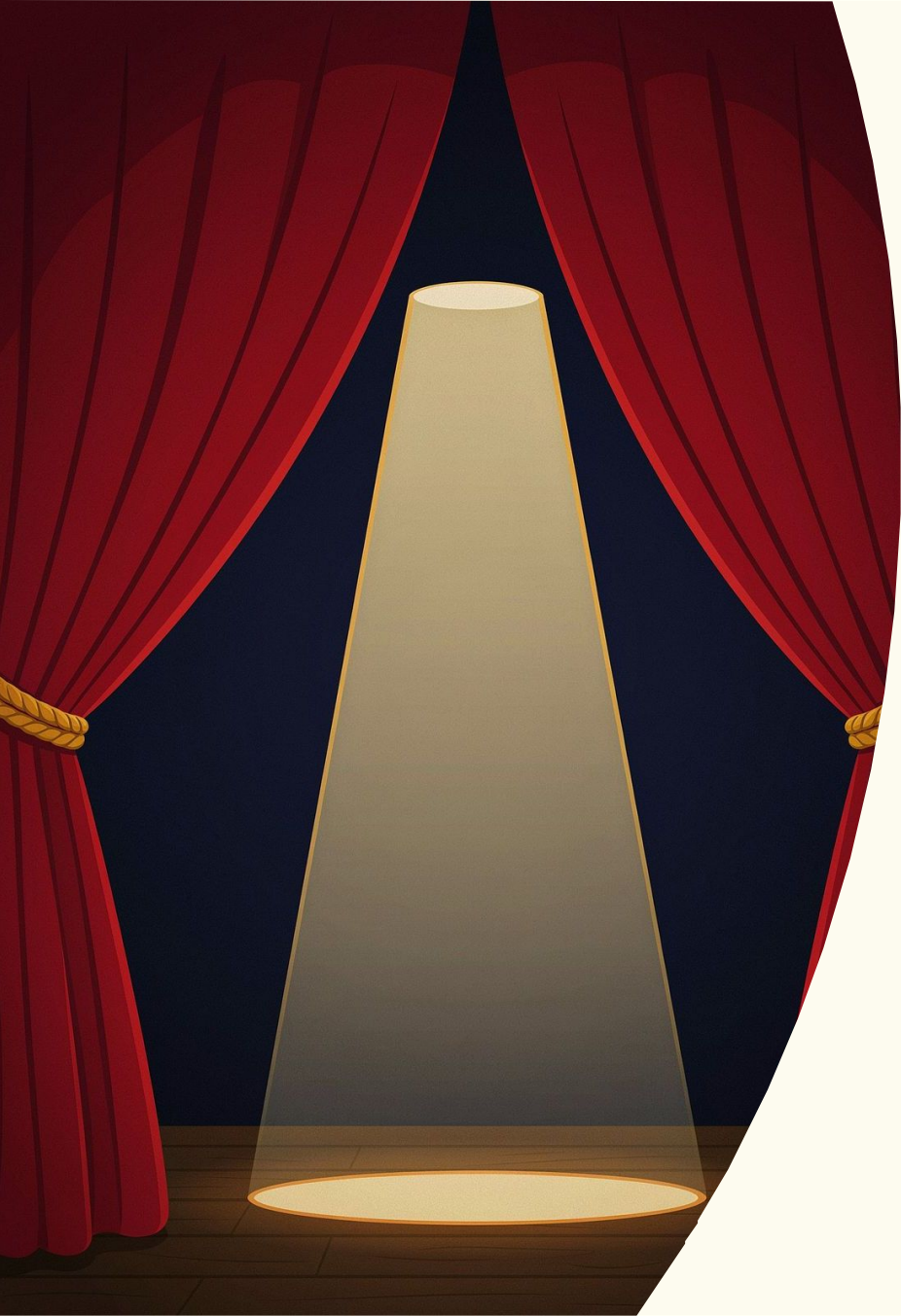




Behind the Scenes

How AI models really work — and how to build with them

Series Kickoff · Saturday, September 12 · Virtual · 11:00–12:00
LLM and AI Agent Community, Little Rock

What This Cohort Is

We pull back the curtain on how AI models actually work — in plain language, with no math and no machine learning background required. This is a community for curious people who want to *understand* and then *build*.

Plain Language

Every idea explained the way you'd explain it to a friend. No jargon walls, no assumptions.

One Idea Per Session

We go deep on a single concept rather than spraying you with a firehose of information.

Ends in a Build

You turn your new understanding into a small tool of your own. Something real, something that runs.

 No math. No jargon walls. Just how it works — and how to build.

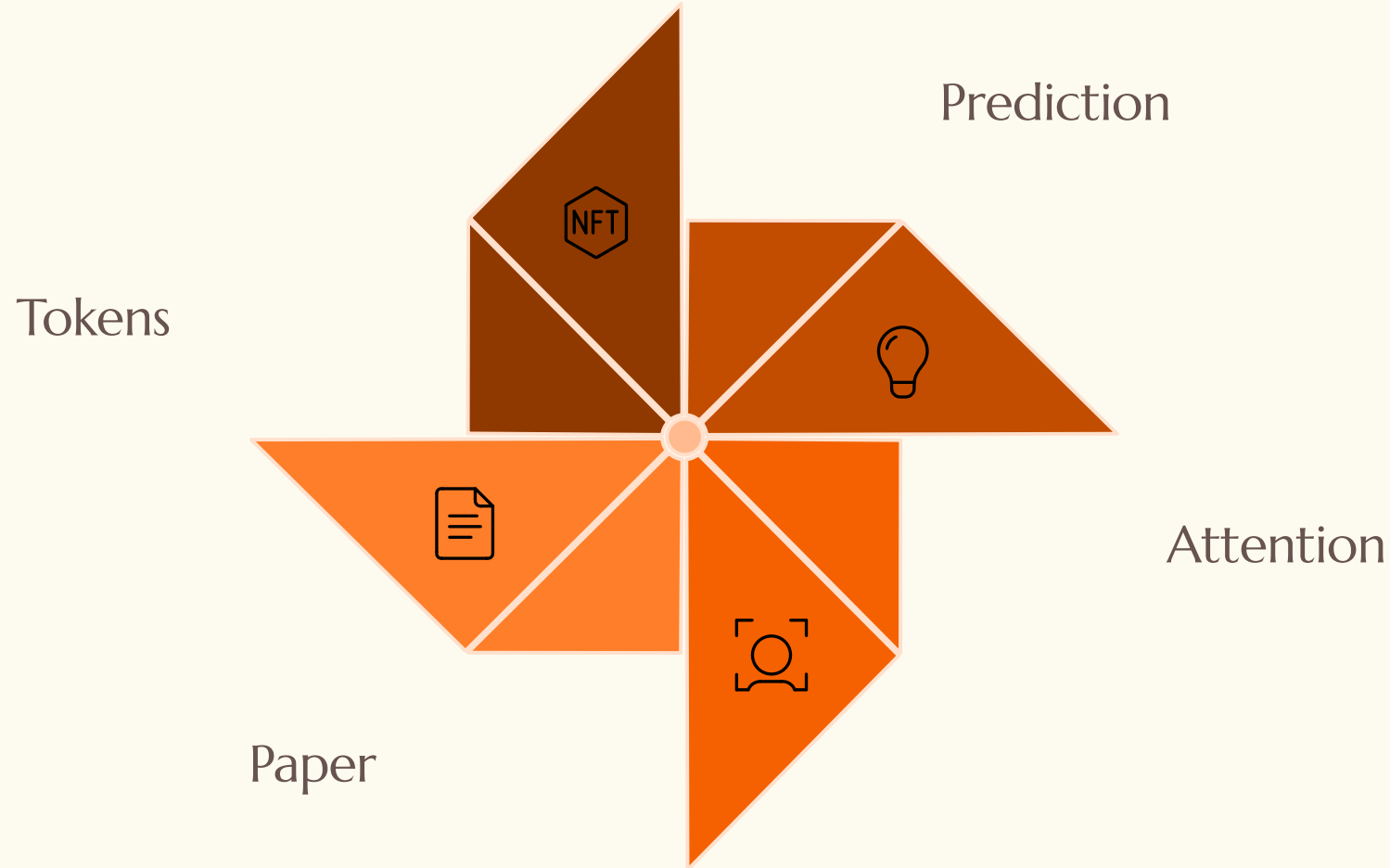
The Plan: Seven Saturdays

From September through December, we meet every other Saturday. Each session builds on the last — a deliberate progression from understanding to building.



How the Sessions Connect

The series is structured in two acts — first you understand it, then you build it. Each session is a stepping stone to the next.



Your words go in, the model guesses what comes next, it decides which words matter — and the 2017 paper shows how it all came together. Once that picture is clear, we build.

Where We Land by December

You Can Explain It

Well enough to use these tools effectively and spot when they slip. No hand-waving required — you'll actually know what's happening under the hood.

You've Built It

A working agentic workflow you made yourself. Not a toy demo, not a tutorial copy-paste — something you understand and can extend.

How a Typical Session Runs

In-person sessions are every other Saturday, running about two hours. Each one follows the same rhythm so you always know what's coming.

O1

Welcome & Latest News

What shipped in AI over the last two weeks — fast, curated, relevant.

O2

The Concept

One idea, gone deep and made usable. This is the heart of every session.

O3

For vs. Against

A sharp 10-minute debate on the topic. Different perspectives, real thinking.

O4

Break

Food and drinks. Catch your breath and connect with the person next to you.

O5

See It in Action

A live demo or short hands-on exercise with the concept from the session.

O6

Q&A & Open Floor

Harder questions, real answers. Nothing is off the table.

O7

Networking

Meet the other builders in the room. This community is the long game.

Today's Hour

Today is virtual — one focused hour to lay out the plan, introduce the format, and hear from you. The full session rhythm (debate, demo, networking) kicks off September 26 in person.

Time	Segment
11:00	Welcome and why this cohort exists
11:05	The gap: AI feels like magic — we open it up
11:15	The roadmap: the seven Saturdays
11:35	How our sessions will run
11:45	Q&A and what you want from this
11:55	Close and next date

 No For vs. Against and no build today. That rhythm starts September 26, in person at Hillcrest.

The Gap We're Closing

How AI Feels Right Now

- Magic black box that somehow works
- Unpredictable — brilliant one moment, wrong the next
- Something you use but don't understand
- Intimidating to build with

How It Feels After This Series

- A system you can reason about
- Predictable enough to use well and catch when it slips
- Something you understand from the inside out
- A platform you've actually built on

Why Plain Language Matters

Most AI explanations are written by researchers for other researchers. The math is real and important — but it's not the only path to understanding how these systems work.

If you can't explain it plainly, you don't understand it well enough yet. This series is proof that you can.

Every concept in this series has a clear, jargon-free version. We will always reach for that version first. When a technical term is useful, we will earn it — by explaining it before we use it.



What We Need From You

This series only works if the community makes it work. Here's what keeps it going — and keeps it valuable for everyone in the room.

Show Up

Every other Saturday. The series builds on itself — missing a session costs you context. Commit to the rhythm.

Bring a Peer

One person who would get real value from this. That's how the community grows — one good referral at a time.

Suggest Topics

If something feels fuzzy to you, it's fuzzy for others too. Surface it and we'll go there together.

Volunteer

Run a Latest News slot or share a build. Low stakes, real audience. It makes the whole room better.

Cadence & Logistics

The Schedule

- **Every other Saturday** — bi-weekly through December
- **11:00 AM start** — plan for two hours in person
- **Hillcrest** — in-person location starting September 26
- **Meetumo** — RSVP so we can plan seats and food

Today vs. Going Forward

Today only: Virtual, one hour, 11:00–12:00. No food, no debate, no build — just the plan.

Starting September 26: In person at Hillcrest, two hours, the full format. Come hungry.

- RSVP on Meetumo so we can plan seats and food for each session.

A Preview: Behind the Tokens

Our first real session — September 26, in person — is called **Behind the Tokens**. It answers the most fundamental question: how does an AI model actually read your words?



Words Are Not Words

Models don't see words the way you do. They see chunks called tokens — sometimes a full word, sometimes just a syllable or punctuation mark.



Numbers, Not Letters

Every token becomes a number. The model only ever works with numbers — never text. Understanding this unlocks how everything else works.



Why It Matters

Knowing how your words get tokenized helps you write better prompts and understand why models sometimes make surprising mistakes.

Who This Is Built For

You don't need a technical background. You don't need to have built anything before. Here's who gets the most out of this series:



The Curious Non-Technical Adult

You use AI tools daily but feel like you're flying blind. You want to understand what's actually happening — without sitting through a math lecture.



The Early-Stage Builder

You've started experimenting with APIs or prompts. You want a mental model that makes your experiments more intentional and your results more predictable.



The Community Member

You want to be around other people who are genuinely curious about this stuff. The room is half the value — bring someone who belongs in it.



The Community Is the Long Game

The concepts you learn here will help you right away. But the relationships you build with the other people in the room will compound over years.

Little Rock's AI Community

This series is part of building something durable here — a local network of builders and thinkers who take this seriously.

Learn Together, Build Together

The best projects come out of communities like this. You'll meet your next collaborator, not just your next coworker.

Grow the Room

Bring one person who belongs here. This community doubles in value every time the right person walks through the door.

See You September 26.

Behind the Tokens — in person at Hillcrest.
Bring one person with you.



Where

Hillcrest, Little Rock
(in-person from Sept 26)



When

Every other Saturday
11:00 AM · Two hours



RSVP

Meetumo — so we can plan seats and
food for every session

No math. No jargon. Just how it works — and how to build it yourself.